Tape

By Jose Rivera

A small dark room. No windows. One door. A PERSON is being led in by an ATTENDANT. On the table is a large reel-to-reel tape recorder, a glass of water, a pitcher of water.

PERSON: **(Pg 211-218)** It's dark in here.

ATTENDANT: I'm sorry.

PERSON: No, I know it's not your fault.

ATTENDANT: I'm afraid those lights . . .

PERSON: I guess, what does it matter now?

ATTENDANT: . . . not very bright

PERSON: Who care, really?

ATTENDANT: We don't want to cause you any undue suffering. If it's too dark in here for you, I'll make sure one of the other attendants replaces the light bulb.

PERSON: *(looks at the ATTENDANT)* Any "undue suffering"?

ATTENDANT: That's right.

PERSON: *(looks at the room)* Is this where I'll be?

ATTENDANT: That's right.

PERSON: Will you be outside?

ATTENDANT: Yes.

PERSON: The entire time?

ATTENDANT: the entire time.

PERSON: Is it boring?

ATTENDANT: *(As if he/she hadn't heard)* I'm sorry?

PERSON: Is it boring? You know. Waiting outside all the time.

ATTENDANT: *(Soft smile)* It's my job. It's what I do.

PERSON: Of course. *(Beat)* Will I get anything to eat or drink?

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ATTENDANT: Well, we're not really set up for that. We don't have what you'd call a kitchen. But we can send out for things. Little things. Cold food.

PERSON: I understand.

ATTENDANT: Soft drinks.

PERSON: *(Hopefully)* Beer?

ATTENDANT: I'm afraid not.

PERSON: Not even on special occasions like my birthday?

ATTENDANT: *(Thinking)* I guess maybe on your birthday.

PERSON: *(Truly appreciative)* Great. Thanks. *(Beat)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Life after death -- Why all the interest?*
ACTOR 2: *With the Baby Boom generation in their 60's and 70's, suddenly the reality of death is upon us in a personal way.*
ACTOR 1: *Too often the subject of death is addressed with goofy speculation, close-minded stubbornness, or outright fear and avoidance.*
ACTOR 2: *So, let's bypass the "Death for Dummies" approach and take a deeper intellectual look at death to better understand the important role it plays in our lives...*
ACTOR 1: *and especially what it can teach us about how to live.*
ACTOR 2: *Written as if human culture were the subject of fairy tales told by giants, this selection makes a statement about Karma and our human perception of the afterlife.*
TOGETHER: *Tape by Jose Rivera*

ATTENDANT: Do you have any more questions before we start? Because if you do, that's okay. It's okay to ask as many questions as you want. I'm sure you're very curious. I'm sure you'd like to know as much as possible, so you can figure out how it all fits together and what it all means. So please ask. That's why I'm here. Don't worry about the time. We have a lot of time. *(Beat)*

PERSON: I don't have any questions.

ATTENDANT: *(Disappointed)* Are you sure?

PERSON: There's not much I really have to know is there? Really?

ATTENDANT: No, I guess not. I just thought . . .

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PERSON: It's okay. I appreciate it. *(The ATTENDANT looks sad. The Person looks at the ATTENDANT and feels bad)*

PERSON: Hey I'm sorry. I know it's not your fault.

ATTENDANT: It's all right.

PERSON: What's your name anyway? Do you have a name?

ATTENDANT: Not really. It's not allowed

PERSON: Really? Not allowed? Who says?

ATTENDANT: The rules say.

PERSON: Have you actually seen these rules? Are they in writing?

ATTENDANT: Oh yes. There's a long and extensive training course.

PERSON: *(Surprised)* There is?

ATTENDANT: Oh yes. It's quite rigorous.

PERSON: Imagine that.

ATTENDANT: You have to be a little bit of everything. Confidant, confessor, friend, stern taskmaster. Guide.

PERSON: I guess that would take time.

ATTENDANT: My teachers were all quite strong and capable. They really pushed me. I was grateful. I knew I had been chosen for something unique and exciting. Something significant. I didn't mind the hard work and sleepless nights.

PERSON: *(Surprised)* Oh? You sleep?

ATTENDANT: *(Smiles)* When I can. *(Beat)*

PERSON: Do you dream? *(Beat)*

ATTENDANT: No. *(Beat)* That's not allowed. *(Beat)*

PERSON: I'm sorry.

ATTENDANT: No. It's something you get used to.

PERSON: *(Trying to be chummy) I* know I went years and years without being able to remember one single dream I had. It really scared the *crap* out of me when I was ten and . . .

ATTENDANT: I know.

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PERSON: I'm sorry.

ATTENDANT: I said I know. I know that story. When you were ten.

PERSON: Oh. Yeah. I guess you would know everything. Every story.

ATTENDANT: *(Apologetic)* It's part of the training.

PERSON: I figured *(A long uncomfortable silence)*

ATTENDANT: *(Softly)* Have you ever operated a reel-to-reel tape recorder before?

PERSON: *(Suddenly terrified)* No I haven't. I mean – no.

ATTENDANT: It's not hard.

PERSON: I, uhm, these things were pretty obsolete by the time I was old enough to afford stereo equipment, you know. I got into cassettes and, later, CDs, but never one of these jobbies.

ATTENDANT: It's not hard. *(Demonstrates)* On here. Off here. Play. Pause. Rewind.

PERSON: *(Surprised)* Rewind?

ATTENDANT: In some cases the quality of the recording is so poor . . . you'll want to rewind it until you understand.

PERSON: No fast forward?

ATTENDANT: No.

PERSON: *(Getting progressively more frightened)* It looks like a pretty good one. Sturdy. Very strong.

ATTENDANT: They get a lot of use.

PERSON: I bet. *(Beat)* Is this the only tape?

ATTENDANT: (*Laughs out loud – then quickly stops)* No

PERSON: I didn't think so.

ATTENDANT: There are many more.

PERSON: How many? A lot?

ATTENDANT: There are then thousand boxes.

PERSON: Ten thousand?

ATTENDANT: I'm afraid so.

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PERSON: Did I really . . . did I really lie that much?

ATTENDANT: I'm afraid you did.

PERSON: So . . . everyone goes into a room like this?

ATTENDANT: Exactly like this. There's no differentiation. Everyone's equal.

PERSON: For once.

ATTENDANT: What isn't equal, of course, is the . . . amount of time you spend here. Listening.

PERSON: *(Horror stricken)* Oh, God.

ATTENDANT: *(Part of the training)* Listening, just to yourself. To your voice.

PERSON: I know.

ATTENDANT: Listening, word by word, to every lie you ever told while you were alive.

PERSON: Oh, God!

ATTENDANT: Every ugly lie to every person, every single time, every betrayal, every lying thought, every time you lied to yourself, deep in your mind, we were listening, we were recording, and it's all in these tapes, ten thousand boxes of them, in your own words, one lie after the next, over and over, until we're finished. So the amount of time varies. The amount of time you spend here all depends on how many lies you told. How many boxes of tapes we have to get through together.

PERSON: *(Almost in tears)* I'm sorry . . .

ATTENDANT: Too late.

PERSON: I said I'm sorry! I said I'm sorry! I said it a million times! What happened to forgiveness?! I don't want to be here! I don't want this! I don't want to listen! I don't want to hear myself! I didn't mean to say the things I said! I don't want to listen!

ATTENDANT: Yes, well. Neither did we. Neither did we.

(The ATTENDANT looks sadly at the PERSON. The ATTENDANT turns on the tape recorder, then leaves the room, leaving the PERSON all alone. From the depths of the machine comes a long-forgotten voice – The ATTENDANT should voice this line from off-stage)

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VOICE: "Where have you been? Do you know I've been looking all over? Jesus Christ! I went to Manny's! I went to the pharmacy! The school! I even called the police! Look at me, Jesus Christ, I'm shaking! Now look at me – look at me and tell me where the hell you were! Tell me right now!"

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